

# Dashboard Design Principles

THE ARZENS (TAS) — Week 08-09 Combined Assignment — Task 4

## Why Dashboard Design Matters

A security dashboard is only useful if the person looking at it can understand what is happening in a few seconds. An analyst staring at a wall of raw numbers during an active incident does not have time to hunt for the important figure — the dashboard has to surface it immediately. Good dashboard design is therefore less about showing every possible metric and more about showing the right few metrics, in a way that is instantly readable.

## Principle 1: Show Important Numbers Big (KPIs)

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) — such as total critical alerts, number of failed logins, or overall system health — should be displayed as large, prominent numbers near the top of the screen, not buried in a table. The human eye is drawn to size, so making the most important number the biggest thing on the page ensures it gets noticed first, even by someone glancing at the dashboard from across the room.

## Principle 2: Use Color Meaningfully (Red / Yellow / Green)

Color should carry meaning consistently across the entire dashboard: red for bad or critical conditions, yellow for warnings that need attention, and green for healthy or normal states. This matches how traffic lights and most safety systems already work, so it requires no extra explanation. The moment colors are used inconsistently (for example, green meaning "critical" on one chart and "safe" on another), the dashboard becomes confusing and slows the analyst down instead of helping them.

## Principle 3: Keep It Simple — Don't Overcrowd

Every extra chart, label, or color on a dashboard competes for the viewer's attention. A cluttered dashboard with fifteen small charts is often less useful than one with three clear ones, because the viewer cannot tell what actually matters. A good rule of thumb is to only include a metric if someone would actually make a decision based on it — if a chart would never change what an analyst does next, it probably does not belong on the main dashboard.

## Sketch: My Ideal Security Dashboard

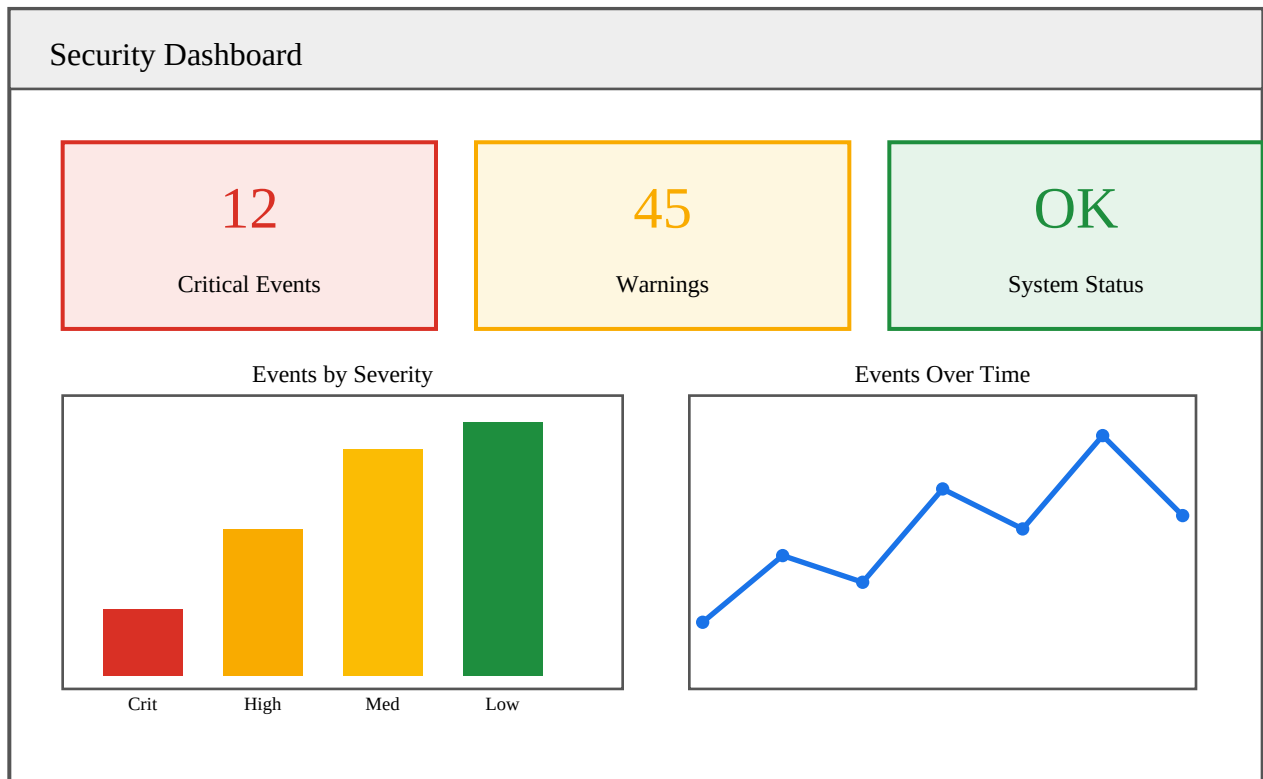


Figure 1. A sketch of a simple security dashboard: three large color-coded KPI boxes at the top (red/yellow/green), a bar chart of events by severity, and a line chart of events over time — deliberately kept to a small number of elements.